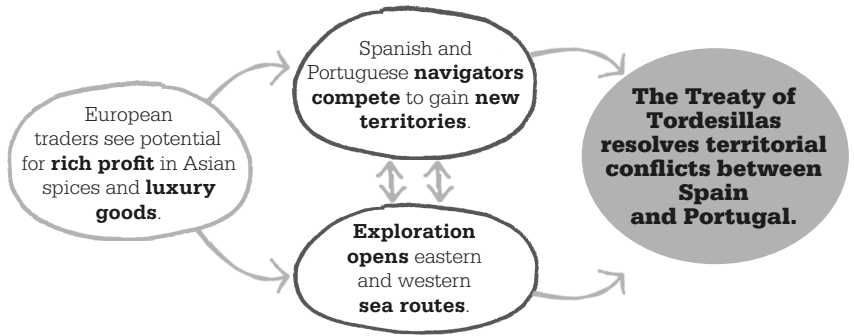




review the terms of the Alcaçovas treaty. The papacy had been involved in the 1479 treaty, and now Pope Alexander VI (a Spaniard) proposed a combined north-south and east-west dividing line, suggesting that any lands west and south of a line 100 leagues west and south of the Azores and Cape Verde Islands be allocated to Spain. John rejected the proposition, considering it to be biased in favor of his rivals, and eventually all parties agreed on the meridian between the Cape Verde Islands and the Caribbean. The resulting treaty set the agenda for future colonization, and influenced the fate of vast swathes of the world.

Portuguese colonies

By the time the Tordesillas treaty was signed, Portugal had already made headway in exploring Africa and southern Asia. Working south from a North African base at Ceuta, explorers established a series of trading posts on the West African coast, gradually pushing south until, in 1498, Vasco da Gama rounded the Cape of Good Hope and sailed into the Indian Ocean. In the 16th century, Portugal had settlements in India, the Moluccas, Sumatra, Burma, and Thailand, and by 1557 they had established their long-standing enclave in Macau, which became a hub for their trade with many Asian communities.

The treaty line passed through South America, allocating a north-western portion to the Portuguese. In 1500, explorer Pedro Álvares Cabral landed on the coast

of Brazil and claimed it for Portugal. The conquistadors exploited their new colony, forcing indigenous peoples to cultivate sugar cane, grow coffee, and mine gold. The laborers died in huge numbers, both from diseases introduced by the colonists, and as a result of their ruthless treatment, and enslaved people were brought in from Africa to replace them. Brazil, ruled from the mid-16th century by Portuguese governors-general, remained a colony until the early 19th century.

The Spanish in America

Following Columbus's transatlantic voyages and the settlement of the treaty, Spain turned increasingly to the Americas, sponsoring expeditions that combined exploration with conquest and colonization. The first of these, led by Hernán Cortés, was to Mexico, which was then home to the small but rich Aztec Empire. The empire's large, central capital was at Tenochtitlan (modern Mexico City). With just a small force of about 600 men, Cortés overthrew the million-strong empire, eventually killing its ruler, Montezuma. Another Spanish leader, Francisco Pizarro, conquered the Inca Empire, which centered on Peru but also included Chile, Ecuador, and large parts of Bolivia and northwestern Argentina. Again with just a small force (180 men), Pizarro laid the foundations of another Spanish stronghold and source of great wealth in precious metals. Peruvian silver became the main source of Spain's income from its colonies. »